Korean Folklore

Beyond the Screen

Six figures. Many traditions. A place to begin.



FREE DOKKAEBI PREVIEW

Contemporary interpretations, with sources to follow.

An invitation to look again.

A fox, a messenger, a guardian: the beings in Korean fantasy carry histories that a single costume or dramatic reveal cannot explain. This guide introduces six of them through institutional reference works, a museum object, and one published oral account. It is a starting point for curious viewers, with sources you can follow.

Folklore is not a single fictional universe. Narrators, regions, rituals, and later adaptations may give the same name different meanings. The story sections below summarize particular documented traditions. Screen lenses and reader questions are our editorial prompts, not claims that every adaptation follows an ancient rule.

Three things to keep in mind

A name is not one fixed character.

A regional telling, a ritual account and a television adaptation can use the same name differently. Variation belongs to the subject.

A translation is a starting point.

Words such as goblin, fox spirit and dragon help an English reader find a foothold. They do not make the traditions interchangeable.

An illustration is an interpretation.

The images in this guide were made with AI assistance for this edition. They are not historical artifacts or evidence of a single traditional appearance.

In this preview: one complete entry, its reference notes and a way to follow the project. The full guide covers all six figures.

Dokkaebi

도깨비

The stranger who may make you rich, frighten you, or lose at its own game.



A dokkaebi can disrupt an ordinary night without fitting the role of either a helpful fairy or a permanent villain. The AKS encyclopedia describes encounters involving uncanny noises, fire, changing appearances, mischief, and unexpected help. The name gathers varied beings and stories rather than one consistent species.

ABOUT THIS IMAGE / AKS records varied appearances, including human and animal forms. Treat a single horned portrait as a design choice, not a universal identification key.

Follow the story.

An ordinary object becomes unfamiliar

Some accounts connect dokkaebi with old tools, household objects, trees, or stones. In a tale summarized by AKS, something encountered at night turns out to be a worn broom the next morning. This background matters: dokkaebi should not automatically be understood as the souls of dead people. Familiar things can become the unsettling presence, bringing the extraordinary close to everyday life.

A club, a hazelnut, and two different choices

One version of the magical-club tale begins with a considerate person who finds hazelnuts and saves some for his parents. Sheltering in an empty house, he sees dokkaebi producing goods with their clubs. The crack of his nut frightens them away, and he gains a club. A greedy imitator later repeats the attempt and receives a beating. The useful contrast is between the two people and their choices; the tale does not supply a universal instruction manual for controlling dokkaebi.

Read the bargain as well as the creature

As a reader, try following the exchange: who offers something, who takes advantage, and who misunderstands what happened? A scene can turn on embarrassment or generosity as much as physical danger. This is an interpretive exercise, not another traditional rule. It helps keep a complicated encounter from becoming only a catalogue of supernatural powers.

Leave room for variation

Accounts differ in appearance and temperament. A one-legged wrestler belongs to some stories; it is not the required body of every dokkaebi.

When you see one on screen

When a fantasy introduces a dokkaebi, ask what the work has chosen to emphasize: a frightening interruption, an unpredictable neighbour, a bargain, or a relationship. Notice what the character wants from humans. The answers describe that adaptation, and may be more revealing than checking whether a costume matches a familiar illustration.

SOURCE NOTES / aks-dokkaebi, aks-dokkaebi-club. See the reference section for links and research scope.

Reference notes

Linked reference articles and research scope. Accessed 24 October 2026.

aks-dokkaebi / Academy of Korean Studies, Encyclopedia of Korean Culture

도깨비 - Dokkaebi

Im Dong-gwon; institutional encyclopedia explanation read. Historical and oral works in its bibliography were not independently reviewed.

encykorea.aks.ac.kr/Article/E0015527

aks-dokkaebi-club / Academy of Korean Studies, Encyclopedia of Korean Culture

도깨비방망이 설화 - The magical dokkaebi-club tale

Park Hyeon-suk; the encyclopedia's summary of a tale family, not a newly collected oral account.

encykorea.aks.ac.kr/Article/E0015530

This guide paraphrases its reference material. A linked encyclopedia entry is evidence of what that entry reports, not proof of one universal version of a tradition.

A question to take with you

What changes if the human in the encounter is the greedy or foolish one?

Keep your curiosity open.

The complete guide brings together Dokkaebi, Gumiho, Jeoseung Saja, Bulgasari, Haetae and Imugi, with illustrations, source notes, a glossary and six reading cards.

The full guide is not on sale yet. Price and release date have not been confirmed. Follow the project for release news.

How the text and art were made

The English text and original editorial illustrations were developed with AI assistance. Reference articles were checked during preparation; this edition has not received an independent subject-specialist review. Images express contemporary interpretations rather than a claim about a figure's definitive appearance.

Read more. Follow along.

Explore the Korean bestiary

https://folklore-bestiary.vercel.app/en/creatures/country/kr

Follow project updates on Threads

https://www.threads.com/@mythoriaworldatlas

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